

ESSENTIAL SKILL

Sprouting

Turn Stored Seeds Into Fresh Food

Sprouting is one of the simplest ways to produce fresh food without soil, a garden, or electricity. A small amount of dry seed can become a much larger amount of fresh food using water, a container, and a little time.

Seed + Water + Time = Fresh food

COMPACT FOOD POTENTIAL

Why sprouting matters

Dry seeds store well and take up very little space. Once sprouted, they become fresh living food that can add freshness, variety, vitamins and minerals, texture, and additional food volume when vegetables are unavailable.

CHOOSE FOOD-GRADE SEED

What can you sprout?

- Lentils
- Mung beans
- Alfalfa
- Clover
- Radish
- Broccoli
- Peas
- Adzuki beans
- Fenugreek
- Other seeds sold for sprouting

Use seeds intended for human consumption and sprouting. Garden seeds may have been chemically treated and should not automatically be considered food.

The simple jar method

Clean glass jar

Sprouting seeds

Safe drinking water

Mesh lid or clean cloth

STEP 1

Add seeds

Put a small amount into the jar. A tablespoon or two is enough to learn with. Seeds expand considerably.

STEP 2

Soak

Cover generously with clean water. Exact timing varies by seed, but overnight is adequate for many common varieties.

STEP 3

Drain

Pour away the soaking water. Seeds should remain moist but never sit submerged.

STEP 4

Rinse

Rinse with clean drinking water and drain thoroughly, generally two or three times each day.

STEP 5

Let them grow

Keep at normal room temperature with air circulation, protected from dirt and insects, and out of strong direct sunlight.

STEP 6

Use promptly

When ready, rinse and drain thoroughly. Add them to soups, stews, rice, lentils, stir-fries, flatbreads, or cooked vegetable dishes.

Moist, not soaking wet.

FOOD SAFETY COMES FIRST

Cleanliness is essential

The same conditions that help seeds grow can also allow harmful bacteria to multiply.

Warmth + Moisture + Time

☐ Start with clean hands.

☐ Use clean jars and equipment.

☐ Use safe drinking water.

☐ Use seed intended for sprouting.

☐ Drain the sprouts well.

☐ Keep the sprouting area clean.

☐ Discard anything questionable.

Raw sprouts carry risk

Contamination may already be present inside or on the seed. Even sprouts grown carefully at home can occasionally carry harmful bacteria.

HIGHER-RISK GROUPS

- Young children.
- Pregnant people.
- Older adults.
- People with weakened immune systems.

People in higher-risk groups should avoid raw or lightly cooked sprouts. Thorough cooking reduces food-safety risk.

DO NOT SAVE A BAD BATCH

When to throw them away

✗ An unpleasant or rotten smell.

✗ Sliminess.

✗ Obvious mold.

✗ Unusual discoloration.

✗ Any sign of contamination.

A handful of seed is not worth becoming sick over.

DRINKING WATER COMES FIRST

Sprouts and water

Sprouting requires clean water. In a severe shortage, drinking water always comes first.

Sprouting can still be efficient because seed can produce fresh food without irrigating a garden, fertilizer, soil, sunlight, or cooking fuel during growth. Plan around the clean water you actually have.

START SMALL AND LEARN

How much seed should you store?

You do not need enormous quantities to begin. Sprouting seed is compact, lightweight, easy to divide, easy to rotate, and capable of producing food repeatedly.

Start with 2 or 3 varieties

CHOOSE SEEDS YOUR HOUSEHOLD WILL ACTUALLY EAT

Practice first, then learn how much your household uses. Store knowledge along with the seeds. A bucket of seed is much less useful if nobody knows how to sprout it.

RECOMMENDED SUPPLIES

Simple sprouting kit

☐ Sprouting seeds

☐ Glass jars

☐ Mesh lids or screens

☐ Clean cloth as backup

☐ Clean drinking water

☐ Measuring spoon

☐ Drain rack or bowl

☐ Labels and marker

☐ Printed instructions

A commercial sprouting tray can be useful, but it is not necessary.

GOOD FIRST CHOICES

Start with easy sprouts

EASY AND FAMILIAR

Lentils

Inexpensive and simple to learn with.

SUBSTANTIAL GROWTH

Mung beans

Useful in many cooked dishes.

FLAVORFUL GREENS

Radish or broccoli

Small seeds that produce green sprouts.

Learn two or three varieties well before maintaining a large collection.

AVOID THESE

Common mistakes

✗ Use chemically treated garden seed.

✗ Use questionable water.

✗ Put too many seeds into one jar.

✗ Leave sprouts sitting in water.

✗ Forget to rinse and drain them.

✗ Allow dirty hands or utensils into the jar.

✗ Assume homegrown sprouts are automatically free of bacteria.

✗ Eat sprouts that smell bad or appear moldy.

✗ Depend on sprouting for all food.

Sprouting should complement stored staple foods, not replace them.

A POWERFUL COMBINATION

Staples plus sprouts

STORED FOUNDATION

Rice + Beans + Lentils +
Oats

+

FRESH ADDITION

Mung + Lentil + Broccoli +
Radish Sprouts

Together, stored staples and sprouting provide far more flexibility than either one alone.

TRY THIS NOW

Sprouting practice

Start with **one tablespoon of lentils**.

1. Put them in a clean jar and cover with water.
2. Soak overnight, then drain.
3. Rinse and drain morning and evening.
4. Watch what happens over the next few days.
5. Eat them in a thoroughly cooked meal.

Ask how much food the tablespoon produced, how much water it used, how long it took, and whether you could repeat it without instructions.

BEFORE AN EMERGENCY

Quick checklist

☐ I have seeds suitable for sprouting.

☐ I have actually sprouted them before.

☐ I have clean jars or trays and a way to drain them.

☐ I know which varieties my household will eat.

☐ I understand that cleanliness is essential.

☐ I know that raw sprouts carry food-safety risk.

☐ I can recognize and discard a bad batch.

☐ I have written instructions if the internet is down.

REMEMBER

Seeds are food in storage and fresh food waiting to happen.

You do not need soil, a garden, or electricity to sprout them.

Clean seed, clean water, clean equipment, and good drainage matter.

STORE THE SEED. ADD WATER. GROW FOOD.

Official guidance

Food-safety authorities advise higher-risk people to avoid raw or lightly cooked sprouts and recommend thorough cooking to reduce risk.

CDC Archive: Sprout Safety Advice(https://archive.cdc.gov/www_cdc_gov/salmonella/montevideo-01-18/advice.html)
